

ALL CLEAR

Andhra Pradesh CM **N. Chandrababu Naidu**, a stickler for 'performance', has ranked his 24-member cabinet based on their efficiency in clearing files over the past six months. Topping the list is minority welfare minister N.M.D. Farooq, while Naidu himself sits at No. 6, and deputy CM Pawan Kalyan is at No. 10. Near the bottom is finance minister Payyavula Keshav, ranked second last—not for inefficiency, but because, in a cash-strapped state, his job is to hold on tight to the purse strings.

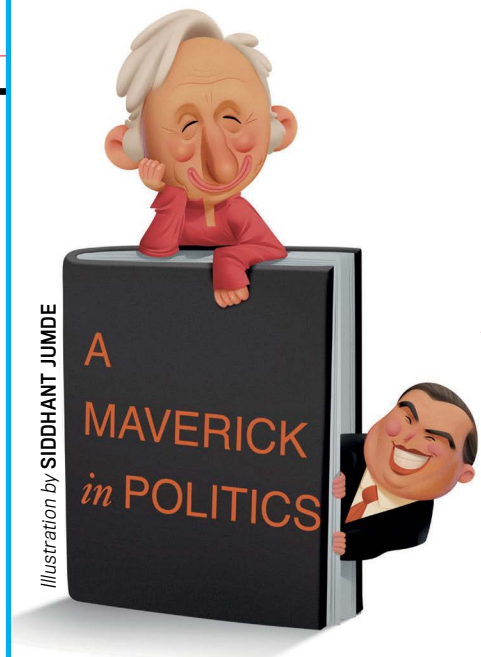


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

WAIT, YOU'RE FIRED

At the launch of *A Maverick in Politics (Vol. 2)*, on-and-off Congressman **Mani Shankar Aiyar** had the packed house in splits with his trademark no-filter tales. He surmised that Sonia Gandhi did not like him initially, perhaps because her "straight, faithful and loving" husband, the late prime minister Rajiv Gandhi, was getting a tad too friendly with the "not-so-straight" Aiyar. Then came the story of the evening: as petroleum minister in UPA-1, he once made a top industrialist wait at his office while he wrapped up a meeting. That industrialist was Reliance Industries chief **Mukesh Ambani**. The fallout? Ambani, who wasn't used to waiting, did not meet Aiyar again, and the minister soon found himself out of the petroleum ministry. Aiyar now suspects it was for his unintended slight.

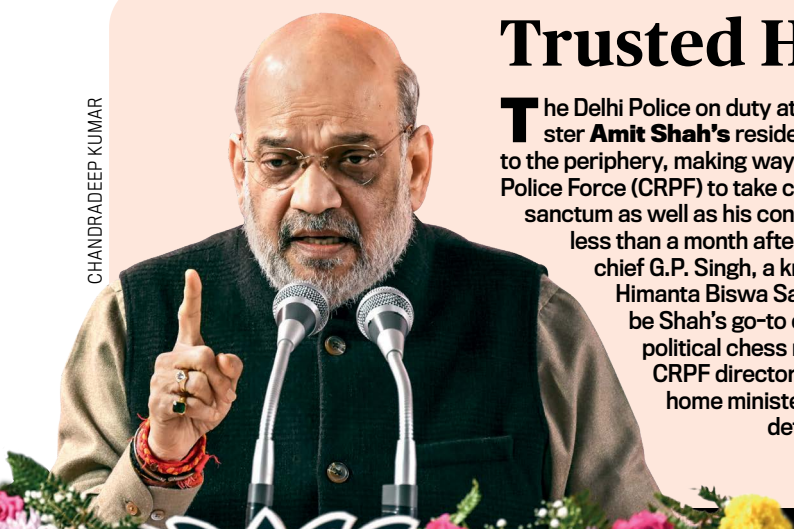
Haunted House

It's been over two months since the BJP-led Mahayuti won the Maharashtra polls, but CM **Devendra Fadnavis** has yet to move into Varsha, the official residence in Mumbai. Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Raut, never one to miss a chance at twisting the knife, has spun a rather dark theory—claiming that former occupant and now deputy CM Eknath Shinde has performed black magic in the bungalow. Fadnavis, unsurprisingly, has dismissed the allegation. He still hasn't moved in, though.



MANDAR DEODHAR

Trusted Hands



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

The Delhi Police on duty at Union home minister **Amit Shah's** residence have been nudged to the periphery, making way for the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) to take charge of the inner sanctum as well as his convoy. The move comes less than a month after former Assam police chief G.P. Singh, a known confidant of CM Himanta Biswa Sarma (who happens to be Shah's go-to executor of his grand political chess moves) took over as CRPF director-general. Looks like the home minister prefers his security detail to be as trusted as his political operatives.

Silent Spectator

At the Bengal Global Business Summit 2025, state industries minister **Shashi Panja** had a front-row seat—just not the kind that mattered. While Mukesh Ambani, Sajjan Jindal and other titans of industry





shared the spotlight with CM **Mamata Banerjee** on stage, Panja—whose department actually organises the event—was relegated to watching the action from a safe distance. Mamata, meanwhile, lavished praise on her chief economic advisor, former industries and finance minister Amit Mitra—her real go-to man—making it painfully obvious that the other ministers were little more than props. Panja did get a brief moment in the spotlight, though—summoned to felicitate some guests before being promptly sent back to her seat.

Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar